INDIA@PARIS 2024

SET TO TAKE A BOW

BHAJAN KAUR, 18

Sport: ***ARCHERY*** *Individual, Women's Team*

Achievements: **Bronze at World Archery Youth Championships, 2023; team bronze at 2023 Asian Games; mixed team bronze at Archery World Cup in Antalya, 2024**

How she qualified: **Clinched her first senior international gold at the final Olympic qualifier in Antalya, Turkey**



MANDAR DEODHAR

Bhajan Kaur first picked up a bow at the age of 12—simply because there was no other girl to represent the school in the under-14 category at a district level championship in Haryana. Though she tried her hand at shot put as well, she found an instant connect with the focus that archery demanded. Six years later, Bhajan was taking aim at the final qualifier in Antalya, looking to make the cut for the Paris Olympics. The form was evident after she finished third in qualification. "Though this was a big competition, I just wanted to approach it the way I do things at training. And I was fortunate to have our coach, Purnima Mahato, and sports psychologist, Gayatri Vartak Madkekar, by my side during the crucial moments," says Bhajan. She continued her fine run to set up a final against Mobina Fallah, the top seed. Bhajan eventually out-shot the Iranian 6-2 to take her first senior gold in an international competition. "I took it one round at a time, to forget the last arrow and focus on the next. There was nothing else running in my head," she says.

When she first began, Bhajan's father Bhagwan Singh, a farmer, would drive her from their home in Ellenabad to Sirsa to train under coach R.S. Nehra. But the 80 km round-trip was punishing, and lasted just six months. Instead, Bhagwan Singh set up a makeshift archery range in the wheat fields behind their home where Bhajan honed her skills. "He keenly observed my training under Nehra sir... he would watch videos to improve his understanding of archery. Twice a month, we would drive 200 km to train with Manjeet Malik sir. Otherwise, my father was my only coach till I joined the Tata Archery Academy in Jamshedpur," recalls Bhajan. The duo would put in two practice sessions each day around her school schedule.

Bhajan's idol through all those years was Deepika Kumari, the former World No. 1 recurve archer. Last year in March, she met her at last at the National Championship. In Paris, in addition to the individual competition, the teen will also get to shoot alongside Deepika as part of the women's team squad. "Back in the day, I would watch Deepika Di's videos for hours to work on my skills. It feels really nice to train and compete alongside her today," says Bhajan. "The seniors on the team are really patient when I make mistakes and guide me all the time. And they also have a good laugh at my expense, since there are moments when I don't really think before I speak." It should hardly matter in Paris, where Bhajan will let her shooting skills do all the talking. ■

–Shail Desai